

GLOSSARY

Appliqué

From the French verb *appliquer*, meaning “to apply”, a decorative technique in which shapes are cut from one fabric and applied to another, either by stitching them in place or by heat bonding with fusible bonding web.

Backstitch

A hand stitch used to seam patchwork. A more secure alternative to running stitch.

Bagging out

A finishing technique that involves placing the quilt top and backing right sides together, on top of the wadding, and then stitching around the edges before turning the quilt through to the right side – thereby obviating the need for a separate binding.

Bias

The diagonal grain of a woven fabric, at 45-degrees to the straight grain.

Binding

A narrow strip of fabric used to cover the raw edges of a quilt to provide a neat finish and prevent it from fraying. For straight edges, the binding can be cut on the straight grain; bias-cut binding has more stretch, and should always be used for curved edges.

Blanket stitch

Decorative hand or machine stitch worked along the raw or finished edge of fabric to neaten it. Often used in appliqué work.

Block

A single design unit in patchwork and appliqué. Patchwork blocks traditionally fall into one of four main categories: four-patch (two rows of two patches), nine-patch (three rows of three patches), five-patch (five rows of five patches), and seven-patch (seven rows of seven patches).

Bodkin

A large needle with a ball-point end and a large eye. Most commonly used for threading elastic or ribbon through a tube or casing, but it can also be used for turning thin tubes of fabric right side out.

Buttonhole

Opening through which a button is inserted to form a fastening. Buttonholes are usually machine stitched but may also be worked by hand or piped for reinforcement or decorative effect.

Buttonhole stitch

A hand stitch that wraps over the raw edges of a buttonhole to neaten and strengthen it. Machine-stitched buttonholes are worked with a special close zigzag stitch.

Chain piecing

A method of piecing together patchwork units by feeding them through the sewing machine in sequence without lifting the presser foot or breaking the thread so that they form a chain with a short length of thread between each one.

Dye magnet

An untreated piece of plain, colourless fabric used to attract loose dye from other fabrics during a wash-cycle to prevent them from

bleeding into other fabrics and ruining the colours. Dye magnets are available commercially, but you can also use a piece of untreated, white towelling. Also known as colour catchers.

Dog ears

The pieces of a seam allowance that stick out past the edges of the fabric when two pieces of fabric are sewn together on an angle.

English paper piecing

A traditional patchwork method for making a quilt of mosaic shapes by tacking the fabric pieces (all of which have some bias edges) to pre-cut paper templates the size of the finished element.

Facing

A separate layer of fabric placed on the inside of an edge of fabric to finish off raw edges. A useful way to finish off shaped bindings such as scallops.

Feed dogs

The thin, short metal bars in the needle plate of the sewing machine, which move back and forth as you sew, pulling the fabric forward at an even speed.

Finger pressing

Pressing a seam using your thumbnail. It is usually used as a temporary solution for seams within a larger piece of patchwork that will be pressed with an iron at a later stage. Take care not to distort the fabric.

Foundation piecing

A patchwork technique in which fabric pieces, or patches, are stitched to a foundation, either a lightweight fabric such as calico, or to paper which is removed once the design is completed.

Fusible bonding web

A non-woven material impregnated with heat-activated adhesive. Widely used in machine appliqué work.

Fussy cutting

Isolating an individual motif on a printed fabric and cutting it out to use as a feature in a patchwork or appliqué block.

Grading a seam

Trimming back one of the two pieces of seam allowances in a seam, after sewing, to help a seam sit smoothly when pressed to one side.

Grain

Lengthways and crossways direction of threads in a fabric. Fabric grain effects how a fabric drapes.

Hem

The edge of a piece of fabric neaten and stitched to prevent unravelling. There are several ways to hem an edge, but the most common way in soft furnishings is to fold the raw edge of the fabric over twice, then stitch along the fold, closing the raw edge inside.

Inferfacing

A fabric placed on the wrong side of another fabric to give it structure and support. Available in different thicknesses, interfacing can be fusible (bonds to the fabric when heat is applied) or non-fusible (needs to be sewn to the fabric).